

NHS Access to Biologics: How the Approval Pathway Works

NICE criteria, DAS28 thresholds and the journey to your first injection.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Review Board** (Multidisciplinary UK clinicians) · 2026-06-18 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Overview



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NICE criteria, DAS28 thresholds and the journey to your first injection.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Versus Arthritis consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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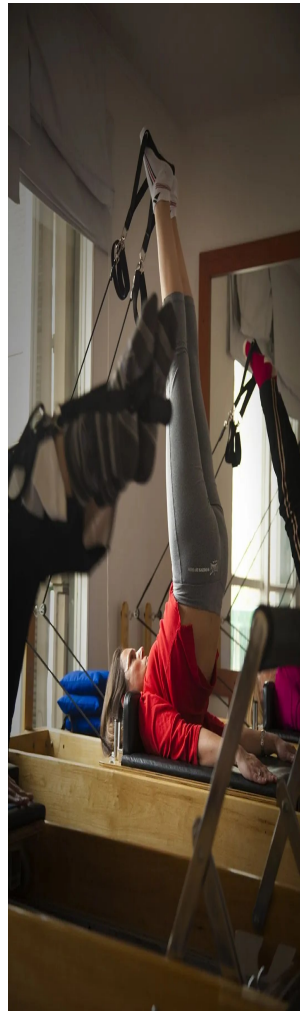
- **Talk to your clinician.** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- **Track your symptoms.** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
- **Move within comfort.** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.

- **Watch the warning signs.** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]](#)[\(/conditions/rheumatoid-arthritis\)](#). 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment. 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.

Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team and reviewed by our Clinical Review Board against UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. We update content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Large randomised controlled trials consistently show that earlier introduction of targeted biological therapies can significantly slow joint damage progression and improve quality of life for people with certain types of inflammatory arthritis. Systematic reviews, which combine results from many such trials, reinforce these findings across different biological agents and patient groups. These studies often compare biologics to traditional disease-modifying anti-rheumatic drugs (DMARDs) or placebo, demonstrating superior outcomes in disease activity reduction.

Current clinical guidelines from leading rheumatology bodies in the UK are built upon this robust evidence. They provide clear recommendations on when to consider biological treatments, typically after a person has not responded adequately to conventional DMARDs. The evidence supports a 'treat-to-target' approach, where treatment is adjusted until specific goals (like low disease activity) are met, often using scores like DAS28 to guide decisions.

Long-term studies also provide valuable insights into the safety profiles of these advanced therapies. While biologics are very effective, the evidence highlights the importance of monitoring for potential side effects, such as increased risk of infection. This ongoing surveillance ensures that the benefits of treatment continue to outweigh any risks, allowing people to manage their condition effectively and safely.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Stopping medication abruptly:** Your condition can flare if you stop without medical guidance. Always discuss changes with your rheumatology team. * **Ignoring minor symptoms:** Small changes can signal a flare or need for treatment adjustment. Keep a symptom diary. * **Expecting instant results:** Biologics can take weeks or even months to show their full effect. Be patient and stick with your treatment plan. * **Not asking questions:** If you're unsure about your treatment or diagnosis, speak up. Your healthcare team is there to help. * **Skipping appointments:** Regular reviews are crucial for monitoring your condition and treatment effectiveness. Attend all scheduled appointments.

When to Speak to a Clinician

It's vital to know when to seek medical advice for new or worsening symptoms. While day-to-day fluctuations in arthritis are common, certain signs suggest you need a prompt review by your GP, physiotherapist, or rheumatology team. Don't delay if you experience:

* **New, persistent joint swelling or pain:** Especially if it affects multiple joints or is different from your usual pattern. * **Fever or chills:** This could indicate an infection, which is particularly important to address if you are on immunosuppressive medication. * **Sudden, significant loss of joint function:** For example, you can no longer grip objects or walk short distances. * **Unexplained weight loss or severe fatigue:** These can be signs that your disease activity is increasing or that something else is going on. * **Side effects from your medication:** Such as persistent nausea, skin rashes, or unusual bruising.

Frequently Asked Questions

What does DAS28 mean? DAS28 stands for "Disease Activity Score in 28 joints." It's a tool used by rheumatologists to measure how active your rheumatoid arthritis is. It takes into account the number of tender and swollen joints, your general health assessment, and a blood test result (ESR or CRP) to give a single score.

Can I travel if I'm on a biologic? Generally, yes, but it's important to plan ahead. You might need a letter from your doctor for airport security regarding needles or temperature-sensitive medication. Discuss any travel plans, especially to areas with higher infection risk, with your rheumatology team well in advance.

How often will I have injections? The frequency of injections depends on the specific biologic medication you are prescribed. Some biologics are given weekly, others every two weeks, or even monthly. Your rheumatology team will explain your specific dosing schedule and show you how to administer the injection if it's self-administered.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about nhs access to biologics: how the approval pathway works?

Short answer: Biologics for inflammatory arthritis are considered under UK guidance, usually when conventional DMARDs have not worked adequately, with DAS28 helping assess disease activity and guide treat-to-target decisions. Evidence from trials and reviews supports earlier targeted therapy for slowing joint damage and improving quality of life, while regular monitoring helps manage infection risk, side effects and treatment response.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk